

Fix wireless network connection problems

Resolve Vista network difficulties quickly, whether at home or when using a Wifi hotspot

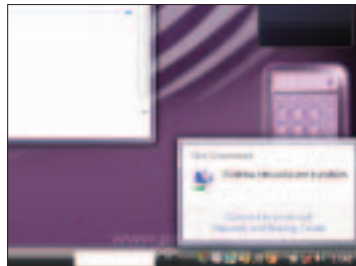
Wireless networking makes life a lot easier — at least, that's the theory. But connecting to a wireless network can be troublesome, though the solution is often fairly simple. By following these six steps you will be able to identify and solve the most common problems quickly and easily.

One thing to make sure of before starting is that wireless networking is switched on. On some computers you may need to press a button or flick a switch before the PC can connect — it varies from PC to PC, but look for something marked Wireless, Wifi, 802.11 or with an antenna or radio waves (on Dell computers, hold down Fn and press F2).

If you're still having connection problems after all your equipment has been checked, then follow our advice to fix the problem.

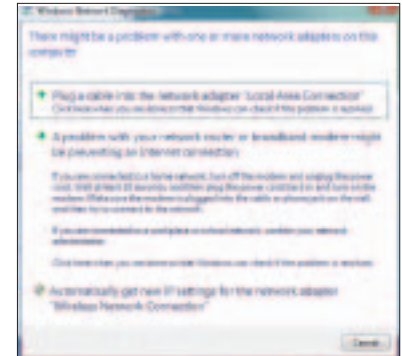
Step 1

The first port of call when checking for wireless network problems is the wireless network icon in the Notification Area, the small collection of icons at the bottom-right of the screen. The icon is a picture of two computer monitors, and if you have a working connection (or if the computer thinks you do) it will be partly covered by a blue-green globe. Hover your mouse over the icon (move the pointer over it but don't click anything) and a small box will appear showing the strength of the wireless signal and what kind of access is available. If you can't see the globe, or if you can but there's still no network connection, the next step is to right-click the icon and select 'Diagnose and repair'.



Step 2

Once you've clicked 'Diagnose and repair' the computer will go through a process of figuring out what kind of connection you're trying to make and attempt to reconnect to it. If the problem is temporary, you might find that it fixes itself at this point. Otherwise a window will appear with further options. Depending on the problem, you may be offered the option of trying to connect again or changing the wireless security key (see Step 3). If there's no response from the network, you could try connecting with a network cable and logging into the router's control panel to diagnose the fault. To do so, open a web browser and type the router's address. It will usually be 192.168.0.1 or 192.168.1.1, but details for this and the router's administrator password will be in its manual.



Step 3



Home networks should have some security set up (on the router or access point). A good option is WPA or WPA2 encryption (either or both will appear in the router's setup page). WEP security is more widely used but is less secure. You will be prompted to enter a 'key', which can be any phrase of text. Remember this, as

Vista will prompt you to enter it when you want to connect to the network. If you're using a paid-for public hotspot there may be no security, but you will need to log on to the network. Once connected, open a web browser and you will be directed to a page where you can pay or log in, if you have an account.